

Insider Attacks

Estimated time needed: 10 minutes

Objectives

After completing this reading, you will be able to:

- Explain insider attacks
- Compare and contrast various types of insider attacks

Types of insider attacks

Insider attacks are perpetrated by people who have authorized access to resources, personnel, systems, and networks. These attacks can be intentional or unintentional. Intentional threats may arise out of malice, grievance, or financial incentive. Conversely, unintentional threats often emerge due to negligence.

Insider attacks are particularly insidious for organizations since they originate from within. These attacks can be broken down into four main types.

The oblivious insider

- Refers to an unsuspecting employee who, due to lack of awareness or understanding, unintentionally engages in an action that exposes the organization to risk
- Despite harmless intentions, can cause profound security implications through actions like falling victim to a phishing scam

The negligent insider

- Refers to individuals who ignore security protocols or bypass policies for the sake of convenience, due to overconfidence in their knowledge, or sheer disregard for laws
- May unintentionally leave a system unsecured or share sensitive information over unencrypted channels, opening doors for attackers

The malicious insider

- Refers to a knowledgeable actor within an entity who exploits their access to inflict damage, steal data, or disrupt operations
- Acts with the intent to harm the organization. Their actions could be motivated by personal grievances, financial gain, or vengeance

The professional insider

- Refers to an individual who has been recruited into an espionage organization
- May be working for a competitor or a foreign government, meticulously gathering and leaking intellectual property or confidential information to empower their actual employers or allies



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